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The Big Fight: Amethi and Varanasi

Like her mother, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra has always been an enigma. She carries the allure of the family surname, yet remains intensely private. Her dressing style is delightfully schizophrenic—she is sometimes seen in international-style designer wear at Delhi parties, and at other times goes native in handloom saris in Amethi and Rae Bareli. Charismatic, charming, good-looking and intelligent, she is a media favourite, an effortless occupant of newspaper front pages and TV headlines.

I first met Priyanka during the 1999 general elections. She was in Amethi, supervising Sonia Gandhi's debut foray into electoral politics. We had a programme on NDTV called *Follow the Leader* and the consensus in the newsroom was that Priyanka would be an ideal choice for it. I telephoned Sushil Kumar Shinde, the senior Maharashtra leader who was then the party's point person for Amethi, and asked if he could help arrange an interview. 'I don't know for sure, Rajdeep. Why don't you come to Amethi and take a chance?' he suggested helpfully.

When we reached Amethi, the security presence around the Gandhis was intimidating. Nor could we find a decent place to stay. I spent the night in a tiny dingy room with Shinde as my room-mate.

'Let's go early morning to Priyankaji's place. There is less security then. If she sees you, she might agree,' Shinde advised.

So, at 6 the next morning, anxious for my interview, I parked myself outside the Munshiganj guest house where the Gandhis were staying. I needn't have worried. The moment Priyanka arrived, she appeared to recognize me (television does have its advantages!) and offered us a cup of chai. I mentioned that we wanted to spend the day travelling with her on the